Those who endorse that line cite the old 'for' case: that it sends a strong deterrent message. The surge in that sentiment after Baruipur reflects growing frustration with legal delays in heinous crimes. 'Encounter policing' has often been projected as an effective law-and-order strategy. In UP, official figures show police have carried out 17,004 encounters since 2017, killing 289 alleged criminals, injuring 11,834. The UP government cites these as proof that tough policing works.

Critics call it an inefficient short-cut to actual policing that normalises extra-judicial justice. The death of an accused ends the very possibility of establishing culpability—or otherwise. Even if guilty, bypassing the labour of patient evidence

Takeaways

- **Prabhas Mondal, accused in the rape-cum-murder of a minor in Baruipur, killed in 'encounter'**
- **While police trot out usual narrative, the debate centres not on whether it's true or not, only if it's illegal or 'necessary'**
- **TMC calls it an "act of police brutality" that needs a review, BJP says it is only doing what it had promised before polls**

collection means accomplices, and past crimes, stay outside clear determination. So, allowing police to become judge, jury and executioner, according to this critique, undermines not only basic principles of law—inter alia, the presumption of innocence—but is a lazy substitute that satisfies a 'lynch mob' mentality.

The Supreme Court, in a landmark 2014 judgment, had laid down 16 binding guidelines to govern encounter deaths. Alongside the prescribed safeguards, it mandated the prosecution of police personnel if the use of force is found unlawful. It also underscored that Article 21 guarantees the right to life and that every police killing must be independently examined to determine its legality. ■



▶ UTTAR PRADESH

YOGI'S SAFFRON TOUR DE FORCE

Besieged by the Ayodhya row ahead of polls, the CM dares the SP on Hindutva in an all-out kinetic war—covering key bases in a whirlwind trip

By **Ashish Misra**

CHITRAKOOT ISN'T A PLACE that Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath's steps have not traced before—in fact, his two-day visit that began on July 8 was his 15th since assuming office. But he stayed overnight, after seven years. And the rituals, both of the administrative and religious sort, were in full flow. Foundation stones for 124 development projects, the inauguration of a bridge across the Yamuna on the district's border with Kaushambi and a defence corridor, financial assistance to young entrepreneurs. Also, a parikrama of the Kamadgiri hill. And a speech that, in characteristic style, blended governance with high-octane political messaging.

None of this is novel for Yogi, who's never short of combative,